Mnemonic flashcards

27 cut-out cards, one per letter (22 letters and 5 final forms). Front: the letter in print and in Israeli handwriting. Back: a picture to hang the letter on, its shape, its sound, a short story, the look-alike to watch out for, and a pointed anchor word.

1. Print on **US Letter** paper at **100% / actual size** (turn off "fit to page"). Each card is 2.5 x 3.5 in.
2. Print **double-sided, flip on the LONG edge**. Pages alternate front, back; the backs are mirrored so each back lands behind its front.
3. Cut along the dashed lines (3 x 3 cards per sheet). Use card stock if you can. If your printer is out of register by a few millimetres, trim the cards slightly smaller.
4. Shuffle, look at the front, say the name and the sound, flip to check, and sort the cards you missed into a second pile.

DRAFT: hooks and anchor words not checked by a Hebrew teacher

Pictures: every illustration is still a labelled placeholder (the image run has not happened). The faint outlined letter is real vector type. The memory hooks are teaching aids, not etymology: the letter-name meanings are real Hebrew words, but the claim that each letter was originally a drawing of that object is only a popular story.

Text source: data/letters/mnemonics.json at build time. Fonts: Noto Serif Hebrew and Gveret Levin (SIL OFL 1.1).

01 / 27

א



Alef

silent letter that carries a vowel

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

02 / 27

ב



Bet

b as in 'boy' with a dot inside

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

03 / 27

ג



Gimel

g as in 'go'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

04 / 27

ד



Dalet

d as in 'door'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

05 / 27

ה



He (Hey)

h as in 'hello'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

06 / 27

ו



Vav

v as in 'van'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

07 / 27

ז



Zayin

z as in 'zoo'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

08 / 27

ח



Chet

a rough throat 'h'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

09 / 27

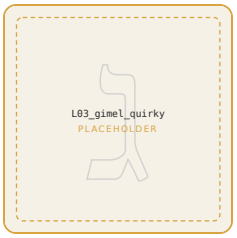
ט



Tet

t as in 'top'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE



Gimel

03 / 27

SHAPE An arched back on the right that runs down to a front leg, with a foot kicked out at the lower left.

SOUND g as in 'go'

STORY Gimel is a Grumpy camel on the Go: arched hump, and one foot kicked out ahead as he stomps toward the water.

LOOK-ALIKE Nun is a bent line with a flat base and no kicked-out foot. Gimel has the foot sticking out at the bottom left.

גָּמָל **gamal**
camel

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Bet

02 / 27

SHAPE A house seen from the side: flat roof, back wall on the right, floor that sticks out past the wall, front door open on the left.

SOUND b as in 'boy' with a dot inside (bet); v without the dot (vet)

STORY Bet is a Bungalow with a Ball inside. The dot is the ball, so the house goes B. Take the ball out and it is Vacant: Vet, with a V.

LOOK-ALIKE Kaf has soft round corners and no sticking-out floor. Bet has sharp corners and its floor pokes out at the back (right).

בַּיִת **bayit**
house

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Alef

01 / 27

SHAPE A diagonal stroke with an arm reaching up on the right and a foot at the lower left, like an acrobat mid-handstand.

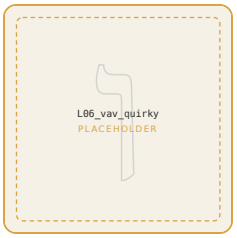
SOUND silent letter that carries a vowel (like the tiny pause in 'uh-oh')

STORY Alef is a mime doing a handstand: every move, zero noise. The vowel under it is the audience, doing all the clapping you can hear.

LOOK-ALIKE Ayin is the other silent letter, but ayin is a curved cup with a diagonal lash and no crossing diagonal.

אַבָּא **aba**
dad

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Vav

06 / 27

SHAPE One plain straight stroke, as tall as the letters beside it, like a nail or a pole.

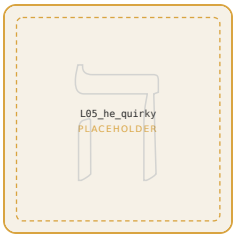
SOUND v as in 'van'; also the vowels o and u when it carries them

STORY Vav is a Vine hanging straight down from the line. Hum 'vvvv' like a vacuum cleaner. It also hooks the next word onto the last: that is why it means 'and'.

LOOK-ALIKE Zayin has a bar on top. Yod is tiny and floats at the top. Final nun is much longer and drops below the line. Vav is a plain single stroke.

וֶרֶד **vered**
rose

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



He (Hey)

05 / 27

SHAPE A roof and a right wall, with a short left wall that stops before the roof, leaving a gap.

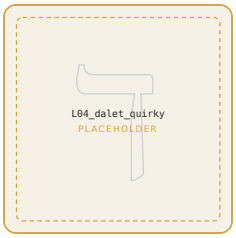
SOUND h as in 'hello' (a breath)

STORY He is a Hut with a Hole in the wall. Lean out of the gap and Holler 'Hey!': the h is the breath that escapes through the hole.

LOOK-ALIKE Chet is fully closed with no gap. Tav has its leg kicked out at the bottom left. He has a gap between the left leg and the roof.

הַר **har**
mountain

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Dalet

04 / 27

SHAPE A flat board across the top that overhangs on the right, held up by one post.

SOUND d as in 'door'

STORY Dalet is a Diving board on a Dock post: a flat plank that sticks out over the water, one post under it. Walk the plank and Dive: D!

LOOK-ALIKE Resh has a rounded shoulder; dalet has a sharp corner and its board sticks out past the post. Final kaf looks like a resh with a long tail.

דֶּלֶת **delet**
door

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Tet

09 / 27

SHAPE A round-bottomed bowl with the right side curling in at the top, like a teapot with its spout bent inward.

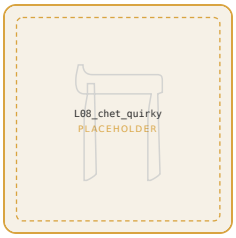
SOUND t as in 'top'

STORY Tet is a Teapot with a round Tummy and its spout curled inward, full of Tea. Tov! (good): a Tummy full of Tea is Tov.

LOOK-ALIKE Mem and samekh are boxy. Tav has straight legs. Tet is one round bowl with a curl at the top.

טוֹב **tov**
good

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Chet

08 / 27

SHAPE A closed doorway: a roof joining a right leg and a left leg, with no gap.

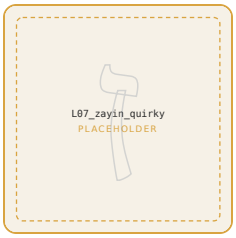
SOUND a rough throat 'h', like the ch in 'Chanukah' or Scottish 'loch'

STORY Chet is a Closed gate with a cat behind it hissing at you: Chhhh! Say it the way you would say 'Chanukah' or 'challah', scraping from the throat.

LOOK-ALIKE He has a gap in the left wall. Tav has a foot kicked out at the bottom left. Chet is closed all round.

חָלָב **chalav**
milk

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Zayin

07 / 27

SHAPE A short bar across the top and a straight stem down, like a zipper pull or a tiny T.

SOUND z as in 'zoo'

STORY Zayin is a Zipper pull: a short bar on top and a straight stem down. Zip it up and say Zzzz. Z for Zayin.

LOOK-ALIKE Vav has no top bar. Final nun is much longer and has no bar. Zayin is short with a bar on the top.

זָהָב **zahav**
gold

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher

10 / 27





Yod

y as in 'yes'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

11 / 27





Kaf

k with a dot inside

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

12 / 27





Lamed

l as in 'lamp'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

13 / 27





Mem

m as in 'mom'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

14 / 27





Nun

n as in 'no'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

15 / 27





Samekh

s as in 'sun'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

16 / 27





Ayin

silent in most Israeli speech

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

17 / 27





Pe

p as in 'pop' with a dot inside

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

18 / 27





Tsadi

ts as in 'pizza'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE



Lamed

12 / 27

SHAPE The only letter that rises above the line: a hook on top, then a bar and a diagonal leg.

SOUND l as in 'lamp'

STORY Lamed is a Lamp post with a bent arm that reaches high over the rest of the letters, Lighting the way so everyone can Learn.

LOOK-ALIKE Nothing else rises above the line, so lamed is rarely confused with another letter.

לֶחֶם **lechem**
bread

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Kaf

11 / 27

SHAPE A backwards C: a rounded shape with the opening on the left, like a cupped hand or a spoon bowl.

SOUND k with a dot inside (kaf); kh like the letter chet, without the dot (khaf)

STORY Kaf is a Kitchen spoon (kaf means spoon and palm!). With a dot, the Kernel is in the spoon: K. With no dot, it is empty and you breathe on it: Khhh.

LOOK-ALIKE Bet has sharp corners and a floor that sticks out; kaf is soft and round. Final kaf has a long tail. Pe has a curl inside.

כֶּלֶב **kelev**
dog

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Yod

10 / 27

SHAPE The smallest letter: a tiny comma that floats at the top of the line.

SOUND y as in 'yes'

STORY Yod is a Yo-yo bead hanging at the top of the line, the tiniest letter with the loudest 'Yo!'. Yod for Yad (hand): a hand flicking a yo-yo.

LOOK-ALIKE Vav is a tall straight stroke from the line to the top. Yod is short and floats near the top only.

יָד **yad**
hand

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Samekh

15 / 27

SHAPE A closed shape with soft rounded corners, like a ring or a cushion, sitting flat.

SOUND s as in 'sun'

STORY Samekh is a Soft cushion with rounded corners: you Sit on it and it Supports you. Sssss goes the air as you sink in.

LOOK-ALIKE Final mem is a hard box with sharp corners; samekh is round all over. Open mem has a gap.

סֵפֶר **sefer**
book

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Nun

14 / 27

SHAPE A bar on top, a stem on the right and a flat base going left: like a cat curled up in a corner.

SOUND n as in 'no'

STORY Nun is a Nap: a cat curled up asleep in a box, head tucked in the corner. N for Nun, N for Nap.

LOOK-ALIKE Gimel has a foot kicked out at the bottom left; nun's base is flat. Kaf is rounder. Final nun is a plain long stick that drops below the line.

נֵר **ner**
candle

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Mem

13 / 27

SHAPE A leaning left stroke and a box on the right whose bottom-left corner is open, like a tent with the door flap open.

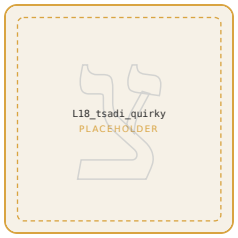
SOUND m as in 'mom'

STORY Mem is a Mountain tent with its door flap open at the lower left, cosy and Mmm-warm inside. The final mem is the same tent zipped shut all round.

LOOK-ALIKE Final mem is closed. Samekh is round and closed. Open mem has a gap at the bottom left.

מַיִם **mayim**
water

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Tsadi

18 / 27

SHAPE A Y-shaped fork on top that slants down into a flat base, like a sitting cat with pointed ears.

SOUND ts as in 'pizza' (a few traditional Sephardi communities say s)

STORY Tsadi is a sitting Cat, side view: the Y fork is its pointed ears, the flat base its seat. Cats ends in ts, and so does Tsadi. Pizza has the same ts in the middle.

LOOK-ALIKE Ayin has no flat base and sweeps in one curve. Final tsadi stands tall with a long stem. Tsadi's second stroke comes from the top right.

צִפּוֹר **tzipor**
bird

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Pe

17 / 27

SHAPE A rounded shape like kaf, with a curl tucked inside at the top left like a tongue behind the lips.

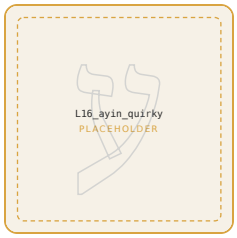
SOUND p as in 'pop' with a dot inside (pe); f without the dot (fe)

STORY Pe is a mouth pursed to Pop a bubble: with the dot it goes Pop, P! Without the dot the lips go loose and the air Fluffs out: Ffff, F.

LOOK-ALIKE Kaf has no curl inside. Final pe has a long tail below the line. Pe has the curl tucked inside.

פֶּה **peh**
mouth

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Ayin

16 / 27

SHAPE A curved cup on the right and a leaning stroke on the left, like a V-shaped eyelid with a lash.

SOUND silent in most Israeli speech, like alef; a deep throat sound in some traditions

STORY Ayin is an Eye winking silently: it sees everything and says nothing. All you hear is the vowel beneath, the same as alef.

LOOK-ALIKE Tsadi has a flat base and a fork shape. Alef is the other silent letter but has a crossing diagonal. Ayin sweeps in one curve.

עַיִן **ayin**
eye

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher

19 / 27

ק

ק

Qof

k as in 'kite'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

20 / 27

ר

ר

Resh

r

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

21 / 27

ש

ש

Shin

sh as in 'shoe' with the dot on the right

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

22 / 27

ת

ת

Tav

t as in 'top'

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

23 / 27

ך

ך

Final Kaf

kh

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

24 / 27

ם

ם

Final Mem

m, only at the end of a word

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

25 / 27

ן

ן

Final Nun

n, only at the end of a word

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

26 / 27

ף

ף

Final Pe

f, only at the end of a word

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE

27 / 27

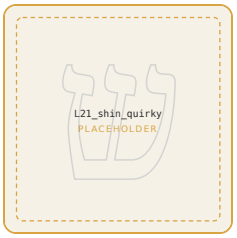
ץ

ץ

Final Tsadi

ts, only at the end of a word

ALEF · PRINT AND CURSIVE



Shin

21 / 27

SHAPE Three prongs rising from a curved base, like three candle flames or a trident.

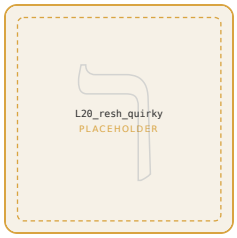
SOUND sh as in 'shoe' with the dot on the right (shin); s as in 'sun' with the dot on the left (sin)

STORY Shin is three flames on a birthday cake with a finger to the lips: Shhhh! The dot at the top right keeps it shh. A dot on the left makes it Sin: a Sun on the left, Sss.

LOOK-ALIKE Nothing common: only shin has three prongs. Tsadi is the closest in cursive.

שָׁלוֹם **shalom**
peace, hello

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Resh

20 / 27

SHAPE A flat top and a smoothly curved right shoulder with no corner, like a head seen from the side.

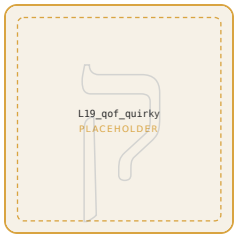
SOUND r (from the back of the throat in Israeli speech)

STORY Resh is a Round head (rosh) from the side: a smooth shoulder with no corner. Rrrr, a growl from the back of the throat.

LOOK-ALIKE Dalet has a sharp corner at top right and its bar sticks out. Resh is rounded. Final kaf is a resh with a very long tail.

רֹאשׁ **rosh**
head

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Qof

19 / 27

SHAPE Like kaf with a long left leg that drops below the line.

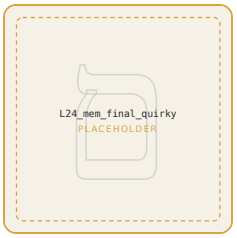
SOUND k as in 'kite' (same as kaf; in some Mizrahi communities qof is a deeper, back-of-the-throat q)

STORY Qof is a Kite with its long string dangling below the line. K for Kite, K for Qof.

LOOK-ALIKE Kaf stays on the line and has no leg below. Qof's leg hangs below the line.

קוֹף **kof**
monkey

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Final Mem

24 / 27

SHAPE A closed box with sharp corners.

SOUND m, only at the end of a word

STORY Final mem is the Mountain tent zipped shut: the word is over, nothing can get in. Yam, the sea outside, ends in a closed box.

LOOK-ALIKE Samekh is a soft round ring. Open mem has a gap at the bottom left. Final mem is closed and square.

יָם **yam**
sea

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Final Kaf

23 / 27

SHAPE A bar and a rounded shoulder with a long straight tail dropping below the line.

SOUND kh (the chet sound), only at the end of a word

STORY Final kaf is a King's cloak dragging on the floor behind him. The word ends and the cloak trails: melekh, with a throaty kh.

LOOK-ALIKE Dalet and resh stay on the line. Final nun has no top bar. Final kaf has a bar, a rounded shoulder and a tail.

מֶלֶךְ **melekh**
king

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Tav

22 / 27

SHAPE A roof with a right leg and a short left leg kicked out at the bottom, like he but with a foot.

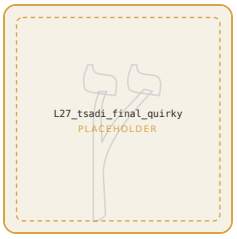
SOUND t as in 'top' (s in the Ashkenazi 'Shabbos')

STORY Tav is a Table with a Toe: the right leg is straight, and the left leg has a toe tapping in thanks. Todah! (thank you)

LOOK-ALIKE Chet is closed with no foot. He has a gap in the left wall. Tav has its foot at the bottom left.

תּוֹדָה **todah**
thank you

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Final Tsadi

27 / 27

SHAPE A Y-shaped fork on top and one long straight stem dropping below the line.

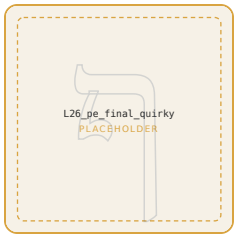
SOUND ts, only at the end of a word

STORY Final tsadi is a Tree: Y-shaped branches on top and a long trunk down into the land (eretz). The tree rustles ts at the end of the word.

LOOK-ALIKE Final pe has a round top and a curl. Final nun has no fork. Final tsadi forks like a Y.

אֶרֶץ **eretz**
land, country

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Final Pe

26 / 27

SHAPE The pe shape with its curl inside and a long right stem that drops below the line.

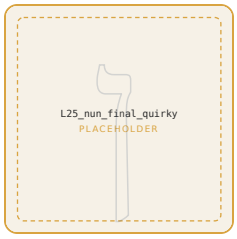
SOUND f, only at the end of a word

STORY Final pe is a mouth with the tongue lolling out below the line to blow Fffff at the end of the word, the way you blow a feather off a spoon (kaf).

LOOK-ALIKE Final tsadi forks like a Y on top; final pe has the curl and a round top. Pe stays on the line.

כַּף **kaf**
spoon, palm

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher



Final Nun

25 / 27

SHAPE One straight stroke that drops below the line, like a nail or a pole.

SOUND n, only at the end of a word

STORY Final nun is a Nail driven in at the end of the word: one straight stroke below the line. Gan, a garden, ends in a straight pole.

LOOK-ALIKE Vav is shorter and stays on the line. Final kaf has a bar and a shoulder. Final nun is a plain long stick.

גַּן **gan**
garden, kindergarten

draft hook, not checked by a Hebrew teacher